Fighting in Gaza

Prospects for peace deteriorated yet further in 2007. Security forces under the control of President Abbas frequently clashed with supporters of Hamas in the West Bank and Gaza. Fighting broke out in Gaza between the armed forces of Hamas and those of Fatah. Hamas forces took control, destroying Fatah's headquarters and driving Fatah forces out of Gaza. Since then Hamas has dominated Gaza while the Fatah-dominated forces of Mahmoud Abbas have run the Palestinian-controlled parts of the West Bank.

Israeli forces sealed the border between Gaza and Israel and took complete control of movement, of both people and goods, in and out of Gaza. They also controlled movement in and out of Gaza by air and sea. The 1.4 million inhabitants of Gaza were virtually imprisoned. In 2008, there was a spate of rockets fired from Gaza into southern Israel. The Israelis retaliated, carrying out aerial bombing raids on Gaza as well as an invasion by land forces. They killed many Hamas militants as well as hundreds of civilians.

Prospects for Israeli–Palestinian peace

Key question
What will be required for a lasting peace between Palestinians and Israelis?

At the end of 2008 the heart of the conflict in the Middle East still remained Palestine and the problem of a people without a homeland. It is now harder than at any time since the 1993 agreements to envisage a viable Palestinian state. On the West Bank, Israeli settlements, with their roads and military bases, control 40 per cent of the territory. Peace-making is further complicated by the fact that the Palestinian leadership is deeply divided between Fatah and Hamas. Israel continues to talk to Mahmoud Abbas and the Fatah-dominated Palestinian Authority on the West Bank but refuses to negotiate with Hamas leaders in Gaza. Although Hamas has refused to recognise Israel (like Arafat and PLO leaders before the 1990s), its spokesmen have spoken of the possibility of a long-term truce in return for a Palestinian state based on 1967 borders.

The real test of peace-making will be the success which both Israeli and Palestinian leaders have in keeping the support of the majority of their people. On both sides there will always be extremists and those who oppose any compromise. On the Israeli side are those who believe that the West Bank must remain in Israeli hands because it is the 'promised land' that God gave to the Jews. On the Palestinian side are those who still believe that all of Palestine must be restored to the Palestinians, even if it means the destruction of Israel.

After 60 years of war, millions of Israelis and Palestinians want peace. The economies of both Israelis and Palestinians are devastated by violence. Israel knows that about 200,000 of its citizens are emigrating each year (mostly to the USA) and that, the longer the violence continues, the more this number will increase. Meanwhile, the Palestinian population grows. This may be one reason why the Israelis have built the wall, their security